duism and the symbiotic relationship between *dharma* and *adharma*. When I asked her about these abiding concerns, she said, "The women in these stories are generally much like the women in the stories I've written about before. Here, too, the women are often wise, sometimes foolish. But the attitude of the men to the women in some of these stories was a big surprise to me, their virulent scorn for women and fear of women. And yet, there were also some happy surprises, as in a version of the tale of Indra's seduction of Ahalya in which her husband, Gautama, forgives her entirely and regards her as blameless...These stories greatly complexified my former view of the depiction of women in early Sanskrit texts."

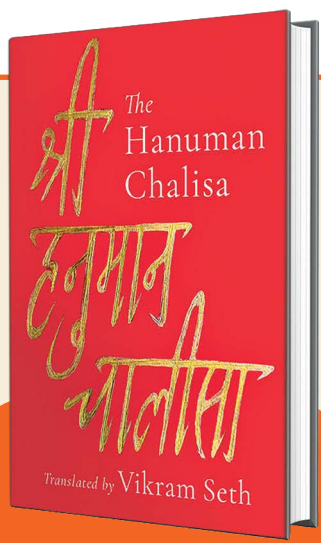
Doniger excavates the stories in *The Dharma of Unfaithful Wives and Faithful Jackals* from the Shanti and Anushasana Parvans of the Mahabharata, in which a dying Bhishma speaks to Yudhishthira, giving him advice on matters of kingship and other human situations. Doniger parses these Parvans, finding the stories that speak to their own cultural context as well as to a larger world of human fears and aspirations. She says, "The people in these ancient Sanskrit stories have always seemed real to me, more real in many ways than the people in my own culture, in part because they hide things that we usually reveal and reveal things that we usually hide. Men and women break out of...social constraints and express emotions that characters in the myths of other cultures that I know have no words for, no thoughts for. There is an intensity in the actions of individuals in these Indian stories..."

> In her commentaries, **DONIGER** gives us new insights and a symphony of resonances and contrapuntal melodies that we can enjoy

For Doniger, narratives are fundamentally sources of knowledge. They are not frivolous nor meant for children nor, as many suggest, for the illiterate or uneducated. Stories can teach many different things. Here, the stories are teaching Yudhishthira how to be a good king, no matter if the tale is about a jackal who eats a camel or about a son who is told by his father to kill his adulterous mother. Doniger treats individual stories like skeletons. She adds the sinews and the muscles and the connective tissue through illuminating their contexts and their connections with other stories. And finally, with her analyses and commentaries, she adds the flesh and blood that turn them into bodies, bodies of knowledge. The stories in the Mahabharata, most particularly, seek knowledge of *dharma* and this is the thread that runs through the selection in *Unfaithful Wives*.

Doniger speaks of the Mahabharata as a "miscellany of stories", but she is able to make them cohere, to be relevant not only to the moment in the larger narrative when they are told, but also to us as we are today with our search for the sources of ethical behaviour and personal morality. As individuals and communities, we too seek knowledge of *dharma*, of how to be good and true and fair and just and compassionate. We really should wonder why those who hearken to the past for everything else, have so little interest in what the *dharma* of a king might be. Yudhishthira would be a fine model for them. ■

–Arshia Sattar



THE HANUMAN CHALISA
Translated by Vikram Seth
SPEAKING TIGER
₹399; 100 pages

sence of this Hanuman in the rhyme and rhythm of English verse and successfully introduced a wider audience to its promise of salvation: "*A hundred times who repeats this recital,/ Freed from all bonds will receive joy's requital* (38)".

The production values of this bi-lingual edition are outstanding. Its cover in sumptuous red-and-gold calligraphy in Seth's own hand bears a Chinese aspect, recalling the author's earlier association with Chinese poetry. This visual opulence is matched by the simplicity of its contents. Two *dohas* (four-lined verses) mark the beginning of 40 *chaupais* (rhymed couplets), and a third *doha* its end, by way of coda. Shorn of explanatory notes, each page contains a single *chaupai* in Devanagari followed by its phonetic transliteration that allows the reader to hear the way the poetry sounds. Its facing page contains the translation in English. This adds to the text's visibility, and the empty spaces between verses breathe with the spirit of Hanuman, the son of the Wind. Perhaps Seth will write a companion volume one day to explain the structure of the poem.

Today, Hanuman is often co-opted by a muscular religiosity, and represented as a fierce warrior. It takes the skill of a poet like Vikram Seth to restore Hanuman to the original conception of Valmiki and Tulsidas–the epitome of service, loyalty, courage, and devotion–ideals that people pray for throughout their lives. As the coda says: "*Son of the Wind, crisis dispeller/ Blessed form, I implore-/ With Rama Lakshman and Sita/ Dwell thee in my heart's core.*" ■

–Malini Saran